



CRUSADE: Church leaders pledge protest against the communists

Photographs by SHANKAR

states KERALA

Warring Red Cross

The hatred is mutual and the animosity old, but the Church's open praise of BJP and debunking of communists prompts the LDF Government to once again lash out against it

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

If Jesus was alive he would have left this church and become our party's Politburo member," this is how M.A. Baby, Kerala education minister and CPI(M) Central Committee member countered when Archbishop Joseph Powathil of the Syro Malabar church—India's largest and wealthiest—said that BJP was more secular than the communists. "BJP leader L.K. Advani has shown much more respect and regard for the Christians than the communists," said Powathil. Interestingly, at the 90th birthday celebrations of Philipose Mar Chrisostum, senior metropolitan of the Malankara Marthoma Syrian church, Advani was the chief guest.

The hostility between the Church and the communists goes back nearly half a century when the India's first elected Communist government was

CHURCH VS COMRADES

■ The hostility between the Church and the communists goes back to 1959 when India's first elected Communist government in Kerala was ousted following a "liberation struggle" launched by the Church.

■ The CPI(M) and the Church are once again at loggerheads over the LDF Government's efforts to control the lucrative higher education sector dominated by the Catholic church which runs a large number of schools and colleges.

■ The animosity between the two has reached a level that a top church leader openly stated recently that BJP is more secular than the communists.

ousted following a "liberation struggle" launched by the Church. Since then the animosity between the two has escalated every time the communists have come to power in Kerala. It has touched a nadir since the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government came to power two years ago.

Recently, the Thamarassery diocese of the three-million-strong Syro Malabar church officially decided to keep out members who believe in communism from holding any office in churches or religious committees. Another diocese declared that all office bearers of the church take an oath proclaiming rejection of "any ideology that espouses rationalism, atheism, materialism, class war, armed revolution and dictatorship of any section". Many other dioceses have also issued pastoral letters which were read out in churches warning the laity against having any truck with the communists.